

ROBINEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and my guest this week is a very special person in British Columbia. It's Robin Castle and Robin is the owner at [adventure house swap.com](http://adventurehouse.swap.com). It's a great system if you have a property and you're traveling around the world to swap your home in adventure locations. Robin, welcome to the program.

Thank you, thanks for having me. Now Robin, how did this all get started? Give me a bit about your background first. Adventure House swap.com is a fantastic concept.

Tell us about it and how you got started with this. Yeah, so about 12 years ago my son was competing in slope style which is a snowboard, you know, the flips and jumps and rails and he was competing all over BC. Quite often our condo up at our home mountain which is Big White would sit empty and we had to pay for accommodation somewhere else for these, you know, competitions.

Just sort of informally we started swapping with other people. We would stay at the mountain where the competition was and they would stay at our place in Big White and so after a few years of doing that my son was out of competing and it just sort of sat in my mind as a great idea and a great way to get to go to other mountains because I absolutely love mountain sports and and I love seeing new destinations so that's sort of where the concept came from. That's a tremendous idea and it's really blossomed this whole system hasn't it because as you say you've got a beautiful apartment or condominium yourself and while it's sitting there it's not earning any money and you're away and this is a perfect way and and I suppose with adventurehouseswap.com you vet everybody so you check them out and everyone is protected.

Absolutely we've been out at about two years and we've brought on board a company that offers protection plans and we fully cover that for each of our members and we really believe them customer service first so making sure people are who they say they are checking the properties that's the hard part about swapping you want to know that you're protected and that we know who everybody is and with a formal kind of swapping community that's what you get so it's kind of like swapping with friends but way better because you know everyone's protected and vetted and is a member so. It started as you say in BC and this has blossomed to all over the world and tell us about your international expansion. Yeah we will we're hoping now Australia is next on our list we're super looking forward to presenting the idea of basically a beach house swap as well because as you know Canada and Australia really share opposite seasons.

Dead of winter there's plenty of people that live on mountains that would love to come to a surf or beach destination for a little while and I'm sure there's lots of Australians that would love to sort of escape the heat and come over and play in our powder so Australia is where we're looking to expand to next of course New Zealand and just this really blossoming internationally Pacific Northwest has been a big market for us because there's so many ski hills both all the way down

through the US and up into Canada making that jump internationally is our goal. Yes and especially with the Australian connection and I mean you being at Big White which is your home mountain is full of Australian people who are working there. I know Big White has a connection with Mount Buller in Australia and they do a lot of swaps don't they and a lot of staff swaps so of course we have our own ski season here which a lot of people don't realize that in Australia we have nine ski resorts and five very large ones and I think that would be a really tremendous market for you to explore that because a lot of people own compartments and flats and condominiums in our ski resorts and that would be a tremendous market because our ski season runs from June all the way through to October so there might be a lot of your customers who might want to come to Australia and and ski with us too.

Yeah absolutely and then you've also got the families of people who are working abroad I've seen multiple posts in our community pages of parents who are coming to visit their adult children who have gone to ski hill in BC and they they have offers does anyone want to swap and so the community is already there this is just a way to put them together this is this is a way to you know list and be able to to look for those exact accommodations and that's a problem a lot of accommodation sites have gotten so large you don't know that you're right at the mountain or you don't know that you're the golf course is accessible or the mountain bike trails and I don't for you but for me when I go to play a sport or or do an adventure I want to be right there I don't want to have to then travel again so that's really what we're vetting the community to be the exact community that you want to swap with. Yes we've got a number of resorts in Australia that are right on the mountain places like Falls Creek, Mount Hotham, Mount Buller that and and Para Sharon Threbo where you actually have the the accommodation right in the resort you you actually live you it's skiing ski out so that's really fantastic and that would work really brilliantly with your people I should imagine and tell me a couple of your favorite places that you've had the pleasure of sharing and and some real experiences that you've had. Yeah I would say you know I just go back to Banff and this area in the Rockies when you swap a home or when I've swapped a home from my mountain out to here experience is just so much different and the mountains that you see and I would say my favorite place my favorite thing about going to a new mountain is jumping on that first chairlift and just looking all around and seeing the different mountains around you and the valleys and you know it's it's quite magical to to get to experience other mountains but I would say the Rockies so far has been my favorite place to visit other than my home mountain which you know of course I'm still very attached to Big White it's great mountain and I've been there it's absolutely beautiful and like I say half the staff are probably Aussies during the winter which is pretty cool too.

I think more than half I actually overheard this family one of my cutest things that I remember was a little kid and they were from somewhere in the Midwest of the US and they said to their parents I didn't realize Canadians had accents and I had to laugh because it was all the Aussies they thought were Canadians. I think there's more Aussie employees than Canadians but the kid probably came back and said oh I know how to say g'day mate it's a very Canadian saying g'day

g'day well I own a channel called ski TV which I'd love to feature your system on as well and I actually grew up in the Australian ski resorts from the age of 20 I was working up there as a DJ and I ended up applying for an Australian broadcasting license and ended up running a radio station on the mountains for at least eight years I spent virtually my whole 20s skiing for four months every year in between my radio work or three months and especially from 1989 I actually covered the 88 Winter Olympics in Calgary for Australian news radio networks as a Winter Olympic specialist and I also went to Lillehammer in 94 with the same deal there so yeah I spent a lot of time in ski resorts and I still do with ski TV I you know I spend time in the winter in Europe filming there yeah a very big ski background for myself and it's a fantastic as you say just getting up on a new ski resort and seeing those beautiful nature that's what it's about the nature and especially with your business those people would really feel like locals wouldn't they I suppose you give them a list of the greatest places to visit on these mountains and areas where they are actually visiting and they become like an instant local because they have a whole network of people to liaise with absolutely yeah and every every listing you fill out what's called a welcome kit which you know we sort of prompt you towards filling that out what are great spots where can you visit another awesome feature that we're just about to switch on is gear swap as well so you know you travel to Canada or down to Venezuela or wherever you're going it's a long way to bring your gear so if someone had the right size gear for you you could just bring your boots maybe and not your skis and it's a whole network it's just a way of traveling that takes away all the barriers so that you're not paying so much for accommodation you're not trying to figure out where to go how to get to the lifts we sort of just help you have that all at your fingertips like you say like a local I want whoever stays in my home to feel completely supported and any questions they have they can access me or adventure house swap is like I say gonna be extremely customer forward that's that's our goal is to make make these experiences just really good it's great it's a really fantastic concept and congratulations for boarding all this together Robin castle from adventure house swap calm they can go to that website and it has I was looking through it before and it has a number of different sections where it you know you've got different areas where people can go to tell us a bit about that just looking at it at the moment you you have things like you stay at each other's places you stay at their place you can join for free you can browse all that sort of thing it's all on the website it's all on the website the concept is you can list your property for free you can browse and kind of see what's out there once you're ready to do a swap maybe you find a property or you're ready to pick your dates then you pay your membership fee and at that time you are basically a full member you have the coverage the protection you can message within the system within the site access other members so so you can browse and see if it's you know someplace that you want to join and you can also list your you list your home and go through the process and see how it works and it doesn't actually have to be a simultaneous swap so if you wanted to come to Canada and stay in my condo it wouldn't have to be at the same time we have a way of keeping a credit system that makes it easy to understand and that's all on the site as well yeah I notice here you've got the ultimate ski home swap guide then the top Canadian golf destinations for home exchange and the mountain biking

meccas Canada's best trail towns for home swaps so it's definitely an all-year round thing too not just for the winter seasons absolutely and we find it's the same mountains that have those big white has an amazing it's a it's a disc golf course but golf nonetheless and then they have just an incredible mountain biking network as well up there and then of course the winter sport and most of the mountains at least in the Pacific Northwest have two usually three sports that keep it sort of a year-round mountain and and they just really sit empty it's a super underutilized time shoulder season or when you would go mountain biking versus skiing so I don't know what you find in Australia if there's mountain biking on the off seasons oh yes yes absolutely huge on our mountains yes very very very big summer can on some mountains is bigger than winter on some mountains it's absolutely yeah because as soon as the snow goes away there's eight months of of summer boom in our in our Alpine regions which is extremely popular yeah and so you might find the opposite of what we do where your months might be your quieter months and and it's just a way of feeling feeling all this time you know so we're utilizing what's already built and and sharing what's already out there it's a great system and Robin castle from adventure house swap calm thank you so much for being on Travel Radio Australia it's been fascinating hearing about what you've done and what you achieved and and we look forward to people swapping with with you and and all of your members it's a great system okay great and if you want to come back to Big White maybe you and I can swap homes oh it'd be fantastic well I travel so much at the moment I'm I don't even get a chance to be at home much so it might be a great system thank you so much for that okay thank you so much